

Sentinels of the Dawn

Poor Clares of Perpetual Adoration
Our Lady of the Angels Monastery
Troyes, France

Christmas 2011 — Issue II

A Shower of blessings for all

December 7th, Vigil of the Solemnity of the Immaculate Conception and the eve on which our Order was founded in 1854, was the symbolic date chosen for the consecration of the altar in our newly renovated Chapel. This special rite took place during a Solemn Mass celebrated by our Bishop Marc Stenger. He was joined at the altar by our chaplain, Mgr. Bernard Savourat, and numerous priests and deacons of the diocese. The Chapel was overflowing with many religious and the faithful who joined us for this joyful occasion. The rainy weather did not dampen the spirits of those present that evening. Rather, they received in return a shower of graces and blessings poured forth from above!



At the opening of the Mass, our Community preceded the priests and our Bishop for the procession into the Chapel. One of our Sisters proudly carried the beautiful processional cross given to us by the Poor Clares of Caluire. Making our way down the center aisle, we entered into our new cloistered Mass Chapel.

The symbolic rite of the consecration of the altar followed the homily. It began with the Litany of the Saints, after which our Bishop inserted the hand-crafted case of relics into the altar. After the altar stone was sealed by Mr. Téqui, our architect, Bishop Stenger then proceeded to anoint the table of the altar with holy chrism. Carved into the marble table are five crosses, one at each corner and one in the center. These symbolize the five wounds of Christ. Upon these crosses incense was also burned. After two of our Sisters cleaned the altar, they dressed it with sacred linens, and finally lit the candles for the Eucharistic celebration. A special thank you to Father Joseph Zirnhelt who helped us prepare every detail of this beautiful ceremony. Truly, it was an event that we



Photo by Françoise Monsallier

Bishop Marc Stenger is assisted by Mr. Jacques Téqui, our architect, during the placement of the altar stone, while Father Joseph Zirnhelt, Chancellor, looks on.

The morning following the dedication of the altar, the Blessed Sacrament was once again exposed in our Chapel in a new Eucharistic Throne located over the tabernacle in the center of the reredos. The layout of the sanctuary was specifically designed to draw one's attention upon entering the Chapel to the Divine Presence of Jesus in the Blessed Sacrament which is at the heart of our charism of adoration. It is our hope that all those who visit the Chapel may find a quiet place of rest for their soul, a place where they may experience the power of Christ's healing love in the Eucharist. On the other side of the reredos is the Sisters Choir, where they adore Jesus in the Blessed Sacrament and chant the Divine Office, the official prayer of the Church. Although our visitors cannot physically see us, we remain spiritually united with all those who join us in adoring Him who is our All in all.

A new case was made for the relics of our new altar. It contains those of the Holy Martyrs Callixte, Eugène, and Sabin, as well as Saints Agatha and Apolline, Virgins and Martyrs, taken from our former altar. Added to these were relics of Saints Bernard of Clairvaux and Frobert, Abbots, and Saint Exupérance, Virgin. The latter three are saints of the Diocese of Troyes. Permission was also given to add a fragment of our Founder Father Bonaventure Herlaut's alb, along with a piece of our Mother Marie de Sainte Claire Bouillevaux's habit, foundress of the Poor Clares of Perpetual Adoration. Deo gratias! After the case was closed, the seal of the Diocese was applied in wax by the Chancellor.













A Beautiful Dwelling Place for our Lord

Echoing the words of the angel to the shepherds on the night of Christ's birth, we come to you with "good news of great joy!" We are happy to announce that our newly renovated Chapel is now open, after having been "under construction" for almost a year. Indeed this is cause for great rejoicing!

We would like to take this opportunity to thank all those who have generously contributed their time, talents and resources to the renewal of this House of God. We are especially grateful to all our benefactors and friends, as well as the *Fondation des Monastères*, who so graciously responded in our time of need. Without their love and concern, their prayerful and material support, this renovation project could not have taken place. The sacrifices which so many have made on our behalf are truly touching. We ask God to reward each one a hundredfold in return!

Also at the top of our thank you list is our exceptional architect, Mr. Jacques Téqui. From the very beginning, even while we were still in the planning stage, he dedicated countless hours to this great work. We never cease to be amazed by Mr. Téqui's energy and creativity! His architectural design for our Chapel reflects his understanding and respect for our contemplative way of life, as well as our Franciscan spirit of simplicity and natural beauty. The manner in which he organized and carried out this project with great efficiency and devotion is very much appreciated.

A project like this one could never fully evolve without, of course, workers who are ready and willing to take on a job. We express our sincere thanks to each company, the manager and their workers, who were involved in the renovation work. From the floor to the ceiling, there was not one area of our Chapel left untouched by professional craftsmen. Masons, painters, electricians, carpenters and cabinet makers, plumbers, metal workers, stained glass window designers, as well as those who laid the tile floors, sanded and polished the wooden floors and installed the sound system. Each one had a special mission to accomplish. Each one gave their time and talent to restore our Chapel to a beauty worthy of all praise and honor for God. The names and friendly faces of so many who worked in our Chapel are forever engraved in our minds and hearts. With their tools and skill, they have left their own personal "mark", so to speak, in our Chapel that will live on for years to come.

Day after day, we witnessed God's providence through the goodness and generosity of others. We received two beautiful altars. The façade of the altar for the main Chapel portrays Our Lord breaking











the bread with the two disciples on the road to Emmaus, a perfect image for a Chapel of Poor Clares dedicated to perpetual Adoration. Stay with us, Lord! The other altar for the Sisters' forechoir came to us from the Poor Clares of Tassin. Both of these altars as well as the tabernacle were acquired through the assistance of Mr. and Mrs Jacques Vuillemin, dear friends of the monastery. We are very much indebted to them for these priceless treasures. A special thank you, as well to a local jeweler, Mr. Michel Schall, who generously donated a great deal of his personal time and expertise in restoring the tabernacle to its original beauty. How it shines!

Last but not least, we would like to thank all our faithful friends who patiently persevered through the renovation work this past year. Many of them joined us day after day for Mass and Adoration in our temporary Chapel. With very limited seating, we were at times packed in like sardines, but we somehow always made room for one more.

As we celebrate Christmas this year in our newly renovated Chapel, we invite you to join us in giving thanks to God for this great grace. For those who are able, we invite you to come and see, to come and adore Jesus exposed in the Blessed Sacrament. The Eternal Word made flesh lives and dwells among us! On that first Christmas night when there was "no room in the inn", He was lovingly received by Mary, Joseph, the angels and shepherds. Let us go with them to adore the Promised One.
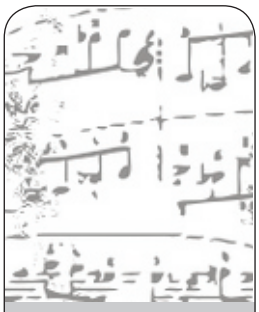


A view of the Sisters
in their new Mass Chapel.
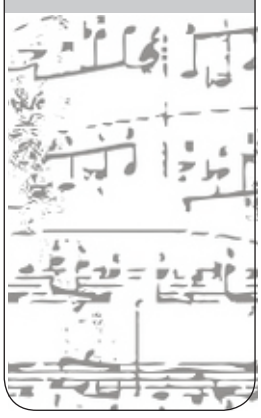


A time of Community prayer
in the Forechoir.





" Fiddling for the Roof" : The Making of a Music CD



It was raining again and we had to run up to the attics with more pails to collect the leaking water. We were afraid the Sisters in the rooms below would wake up with a pile of soggy plaster on their heads! Our Chapel renovations were about halfway finished, thanks to dear friends and benefactors, but other parts of the buildings were urgently calling for attention. In these times of financial crisis, major funding is more difficult to find than ever before. What can we do, we pondered over and over. Then the idea came that I could record a violin CD as a fundraising project. I'd be "fiddling" FOR the roof!

After obtaining all the necessary permissions, the pathway was clear. The time had come to dust off my violin, start rehearsing with the organist, and record the music at the Cathedral. What a joy to be accompanied by the Titular Organist of the Cathedral of Saints Peter and Paul in Troyes, Michael Matthes, an internationally known concert organist and recording artist. Our deepest gratitude goes to all who were involved even indirectly with the creation of our CD: our Bishop Marc Stenger, the Rector of the Cathedral, Father Dominique Roy, our sound engineer Luc Fourneau, and most especially Michael himself.



As a former professional violinist, I have performed in countless concerts with just about every possible combination of musical instruments, including performances as a symphony player with some of the world's greatest soloists. Rarely have I experienced the joy of playing with an organist of such high musical caliber and depth of spirituality. Michael's tremendous love for music is founded upon his deep faith, a faith which impels him to serve the Church and to serve others with his music. After thanking him for the privilege of performing with him, he replied that he hadn't done much... his role was just the joy of making music, which is a gift from God! If you are interested in ordering a copy simply go to EWTN"s Religious Catalog website to purchase it directly online:

http://www.ewtn.com/cataloguefeatured/

Click on Shop Now, and find the search box at upper right. Type in the item number : HCVFS
You may also order it by phone :
1-800-854-6316

The cost of the CD is $20. All proceeds will go to helping us renovate our monastery. We hope you will like the joyful sounds of our CD. Thank you, and may God reward you! Watch EWTN also to view the special promo.

www.ewtn.com

- Sister Mary Antoinette

Adieu to a faithful friend



On October 1st one of our dear friends, Madame Nicole Hany-Longuespe, passed from this world to our Heavenly Father after suffering from a serious illness. She was well known in the Troyes area as a fine professor, author, and Conservator of Art. Shortly after our arrival until her health declined, Madame Hany graciously offered lessons on French history, literature, and sacred art to several of our Sisters. Her passion for these subjects and her lively character made these weekly sessions unforgettable. Thanks to slideshows that she prepared for us with her husband, we discovered the beauty of many churches in our own diocese of Troyes and other areas in France, and we even "travelled" to the Holy Land and the eternal city of Rome, without ever having to leave the cloister!

Although Madame Hany was a great intellectual, her love for life, for her family, and her deep faith in God were revealed in simple, unmistakable ways. Before the Most Blessed Sacrament we present our continual thanksgiving to God for her goodness to our Community and for her faithful friendship. To her husband, Mr. John Hany, her three sons and other family members, we express our deep sympathy. May she rest in the eternal peace of Christ.

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The Poor Clares of
Perpetual Adoration
in Troyes, France
wish you and
your loved ones
a Blessed Christmas
and
a Grace-filled
New Year !